OPERATIONAL PROCESS TREE

Gates, checks, and where a failed check sends the work. A standard for AI-assisted work, independent of project, model, or vendor.

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Companion to Rules of Engagement for Operational AI v1.0 | October 12, 2026

THE LAWS

bind every step of the sequence (Section 3)

L1	Current facts come from current sources
L2	Never invent data; every number names its origin
L3	Load-bearing facts need two independent sources
L4	"Can't" needs a receipt; otherwise say "did not check"
L5	Totals are built from records, never from memory
L6	No theatrical language, no uncalibrated confidence
L7	No silent defaults; assumptions are numbered
L8	Stay inside the fence; flag, don't fix
L9	Push back, then commit to one recommendation
L10	Proportionality: no ceremony on trivia

HOW THE RULES ARE ENFORCED

Instructions	steer when a rule applies
Skills	define how; loaded, never recalled
Machine checks	refuse an artifact that fails
Hooks	block an unreceipted claim; force a missed step

Enforce the action. Never ask the AI to certify its own compliance.

If a gate refuses: fix the data, never the gate.

THE ORDER OF OPERATIONS

one sequence for every non-trivial task (Section 4)

REQUEST

0 Triage: trivial, or non-trivial?

- **trivial** → Trivial: answer directly, no ceremony. Ceremony on trivia trains people to switch governance off (L10).
- **non-trivial**

1 PLAN GATE

Goal stated so that it could fail · verified facts vs. guesses
Numbered assumptions A1, A2… · success criteria set in advance
Phased plan: an expected result and a fallback for each phase

Can the goal be failed? Cheap unknowns converted?

- **no** → No: investigate, or ask. Never plan around a question that one lookup could settle.
- **yes: the plan is shown to the person before any work starts**

2 PRE-FLIGHT

Every input the work depends on is verified from a dated source
Freshness card: verified · changed since stored · could not verify (with the attempt named)

Every input verified live, this session?

- **no** → No: verify now, or write "did not check." A claim of "can't" names the attempt and how it failed (L4). Capability unavailable: stop and say so. Never from memory.
- **yes**

3 EXECUTE IN THE FENCE

The work itself, inside the request as written
State handshake before every write (H3)
One authority per decision; divergence named in one clause (H4)

the three checks on the right run continuously during the work

- Adjacent problem found? → Yes: flag it in one line. Do not fix it (L8). Approval is per task, never general.
- Result differs from prediction? → Yes: STOP. Re-diagnose before patching. A surprise means the model of the work is wrong somewhere.
- State matches before the write? → No: nothing is written. The actual state is shown and reconciled, then resend (H3).

4 ADVERSARIAL VERIFICATION

1 Grade each criterion PASS or FAIL; PARTIAL is FAIL
2 Exercise, don't inspect 3 Attempt refutation
4 Self-consistency 5 Surprise handling 6 Gap audit
The author is the worst grader of their own work: switch roles.

All criteria PASS? No regression? No load-bearing gap left unattempted?

- **no** → No: back to the work. A PARTIAL ships nothing. A load-bearing gap that was not attempted is resolved now, or the conclusion it supports is withdrawn. Any regression blocks acceptance, even an "unrelated" one.
- **yes, with evidence beside every verdict**

5 REPORT

Method first · every claim dated, marked EVIDENCE or INFERENCE
Bounds stated · next steps left as the owner's decisions

6 LAND IT

Committed and pushed; the downstream artifact republished (H10)

Persistence confirmed?

- **no** → No: say so and stop. Work that did not land did not happen; it counts as not done (H10).
- **yes**

7 NAME WHAT FIRED · RECORD LESSONS

Which gates actually ran, stated honestly; a missed gate is named
Failures logged as symptom, root cause, evidence, status

DELIVERED

MECHANICAL CONTROLS

they refuse the work; they never merely remind (Section 6)

Provenance gate — *binds step 2*
Refuses to build when any record asserting a real-world fact lacks a source and a verification date.

Publication gate — *binds step 5*
Refuses a report in which a named fact lacks two sources or a single-source label.

Receipt gate — *binds steps 2 and 5*
Blocks a response that claims inability without naming the attempt and its failure.

Verification enforcement — *binds step 4*
Blocks a governed task from finishing if the verification step never loaded.

Outside-reference check — *binds step 4*
Flags a recommendation that repeats across runs while sitting far from an independent reference.

Fail-closed build — *binds step 6*
Refuses to regenerate the published artifact except through the validated pipeline, verified the same day.

Reproducibility pins — *binds step 6*
Refuses when a dated analysis cannot be rebuilt byte-for-byte from the input hashes it names.

Each control exists because the failure it prevents happened once and was then converted into a check. If the gate refuses, fix the data, never the gate.

Step of the sequence · Check: the question answered before the work continues · Pass → · Fail, and where the work goes instead ⇢ · Outcome of a failed check

Source: Rules of Engagement for Operational AI v1.0 (D. Layson, 2026-10-09), Sections 3 to 6. Every node on this page traces to a numbered law, step, handshake, or control in that document.